

everywhere and are often carrying with them every day a device that won't allow them to escape their habit—their smartphone.

Let's look at shopping addiction. In the US study 'The Prevalence of Compulsive Buying', researchers discovered that compulsive shopping affects approximately 5 per cent of people and females are nine times more likely to be affected than males. However, I believe that compulsive buying is likely to increase for men with the evolution of digital commerce. It's simply much faster and easier to spend now than ever before.

While compulsive buying is not listed as an addiction in the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders (DSM), researchers have been recognising its cause and effect for some time. As early as 1915, the German psychiatrist Emil Kraepelin described it in his textbook *Psychiatrie* as 'buying maniacs (oniomaniacs) in whom even buying is compulsive and leads to senseless contraction of debts with continuous delay of payment until a catastrophe clears the situation a little—a little bit, never altogether, because they never admit to all their debt'.

In an article, '5 Patterns of Compulsive Buying', Shahram Heshmat lists the stages a compulsive shopper goes through as being similar to other addictive disorders:

- Making impulse purchases and hiding these purchases from others
- Experiencing a "Buyers high"
- Using shopping to fulfil unresolved emotions and feelings
- Feeling regret once the purchase after the purchase has been made
- Pain from the unresolved experience of shopping and then moving to step one again

While the book series Shopaholics might have seemed cute and funny, compulsive shopping isn't a laughing matter. Instead, shopping is something we're actively encouraged to do by media, by retailers and by our peers, and, as a result, compulsive shoppers' behaviour is often normalised.

As with other addictive behaviours, what we do understand is that willpower and self-control alone simply doesn't stop the behaviour. Donald Black, in his 2016 article 'A review of compulsive buying disorder', reported that '92 per cent tried to resist their urges (to compulsively shop)